Meeting Discussion Document

Product Discovery & Strategy Session

Date: June 22 2026
Participants: John Bower (Fitness Domain Expert / Personal Trainer), Ahamed (Technology & Product Lead)
Location: Hong Kong
Duration: Approximately 60 minutes | **9.45 AM HKT**
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1. Meeting Purpose

The meeting served as an initial product discovery and design thinking session for a proposed fitness and health data management application. The objective was to articulate the problem space, identify market gaps, define the core value proposition, and establish a starting point for prototype development.

2. Problem Statement

The central problem identified is that every individual must make daily decisions about what to do to improve and maintain their body. Currently, this problem is solved through three channels: self-study, group classes, or individual coaching. None of these channels is well-served by existing technology in a way that centres the individual's needs and ownership of their own data.

The discussion identified a "tree of problems," all of which stem from this fundamental daily decision-making challenge. The complexity increases as the individual ages, engages multiple professionals, travels, changes programs, or encounters injuries and medical constraints.

3. Market Gap Analysis

3.1 Existing App Categories

The market was characterised as fragmented across several categories, none of which adequately serves the individual:

Self-tracking apps allow individuals to log their own activities but provide no mechanism for professional review, coaching input, or decision-support. They do not enable the user to delegate oversight to a trainer or to receive programming suggestions.

Business management apps (for gym owners and trainers) focus on membership, scheduling, sign-ups, and client data management. Their primary design intent is for the business owner to control and own the client's data, making them unsatisfying for the end user despite offering useful scheduling functions.

Trainer-owned coaching apps allow a trainer to create sub-accounts for clients and schedule programming. However, these lock the client into a single trainer relationship. The client cannot use the app for independent activities, and the app does not integrate with other tracking tools the client may use.

Generalized training plan platforms (e-books, YouTube programs, spreadsheets) are popular but unsupervised, generic, and not tailored to the individual. There is no mechanism to load these into a personal plan, compare them against current programming, or adapt them to individual constraints.

Wearable ecosystems (Garmin, Apple Health, Google Health, WHOOP/Hume Band) consolidate physiological tracking data but do not address programming, coaching communication, or multi-professional coordination.

3.2 Specific Competitor Reference Points

Renaissance Periodization (RP Hypertrophy App): The only app identified that makes a rudimentary attempt to monitor recovery and fatigue and to adjust programming in real time. Recognised as innovative but improvable.

Garmin: Provides a movement database with manual entry, inertial rep-counting, and rep timing. However, it does not calculate or surface 1RM data, does not provide progression analysis over time, and does not facilitate coach-client communication.

Strava: Noted as an interesting case study in the dichotomy between device-based tracking and social/community features. Flagged for future detailed exploration.

MyFitnessPal: Cited as an exemplary model for database-driven data capture in nutrition — the user simply types a food item and the nutritional profile is pre-loaded. An analogous database will be required for movements and muscle activation mapping.

Property developer gym app (unnamed): A local Hong Kong example where a property developer created an app for trainers to book gym space and for clients to pay trainers. Again, this model controls the client rather than serving them.

3.3 Key Gaps Identified

No existing app was found that makes it easy to extract 1RM (one-rep maximum) from current performance data. No app adequately models progressive overload by surfacing historical maximums with temporal context (when the previous max was achieved). No app coordinates data sharing across multiple professionals serving the same client. No app gives the individual ownership and portability of their complete fitness and health data.

4. Core Value Proposition

4.1 The Single-Sentence Summary

"Who owns the data?"

The central pain point, distilled to its simplest form, is that the individual whose body is being trained does not currently own their own fitness and health data. Trainers keep logs that clients cannot access. Each professional the client engages starts from zero. The client cannot describe their history because they lack both the data and the professional vocabulary.

4.2 The Vision

The product envisions a client-owned data platform where the individual maintains a comprehensive record of their physical training, health constraints, and performance history. This data can then be selectively shared with a team of professionals — fitness coaches, sports coaches, physiotherapists, dieticians, and medical practitioners — through role-based access control.

The analogy offered was that of a "Health ID" — similar in concept to a Hong Kong ID card but for one's physical health and fitness data. The individual carries this identity across all professional relationships, eliminating duplication, data loss, and the friction of switching between providers.

5. Key Training Variables Identified

5.1 Muscular Development (Strength Training)

The elemental data points required for capturing strength training activity are: weight (load), repetitions (reps), sets, and RPE/RIR (Rate of Perceived Exertion / Reps in Reserve). These four variables form the minimum viable data capture for any strength-based session.

5.2 Cardiovascular Training

The equivalent data points for cardio-based activity are: intensity, duration, and sets (intervals).

5.3 Two Critical Derived Variables

Current strength per movement (1RM): The one-rep maximum for each exercise movement, derived from performance data (e.g., using established calculators that extrapolate from 2RM or 5RM). This is the foundation of all programming decisions — determining how much load to prescribe requires knowing the client's current maximum. The fact that no app makes this extraction easy represents a significant opportunity.

Current state of recovery and fatigue: As individuals age, recovery becomes increasingly important. The ability to model fatigue accumulation and recovery status — and to adjust programming accordingly to avoid overtraining — represents both a major pain point and innovation opportunity. Overtraining is described as a "global problem" that is largely unaddressed by current technology. The statistic was cited that 50% of recreational runners have a running injury at any given time, illustrating the scale of the overtraining problem.

6. Architectural Principles

6.1 Foundation on Known Physiology

The architecture must be founded on physiological systems that have been understood for hundreds of years and have existed for millions: muscular systems, energy systems, cardiovascular systems, and respiratory systems. These are universal across all life and will remain relevant indefinitely. Any future decision-making about human self-care will necessarily depend on high-quality data regarding muscular activation, cardiovascular activation, current capability, and recent history.

6.2 Flexibility for Emerging Areas

The health and fitness landscape is characterised as emerging and not fully defined. Approaching it as a solved problem is described as "a recipe for failure." The architecture must therefore layer flexibility and uncertainty on top of the stable physiological foundation, anticipating that future layers (nutrition science, AI coaching, DNA-based personalisation, advanced wearable integration) will require data structures not yet fully specified.

6.3 Garbage In, Garbage Out

The competitive advantage lies in anticipating the records that future planning and coaching systems (whether human, AI, or hybrid) will rely upon. High-quality, structured data capture today creates the foundation for all future intelligence layers. The system is conceived as "a series of inputs and outputs" that collects high-quality data about a person's current health and fitness status, which can then be reviewed by a personal trainer, an LLM, or a multidisciplinary team.

6.4 Required Databases

Movement Library: A comprehensive catalogue of exercise movements (e.g., bench press, T-bar row, French press, dislocation). This is analogous to MyFitnessPal's food database.

Muscle Activation Mapping: A separate library mapping which muscles are affected by each movement and to what degree (e.g., back squat activates quads, hamstrings, and core; calf raise activates calves). This database may exist in open-source form or may need to be created.

7. Stakeholder Ecosystem

The product must ultimately serve a multidisciplinary care team centred around the individual client. Stakeholders identified include: fitness/strength coaches, sports coaches (running, tennis, etc.), dieticians/nutritionists, physiotherapists, medical doctors (including specialists such as cardiologists), and massage therapists. Each stakeholder requires different views of the client's data, and activities performed with one (e.g., a massage, a physio session) affect the programming decisions of others.

The PARQ (Physical Activity Readiness Questionnaire) was identified as the starting data capture instrument — the client intake form that initiates the professional relationship. The core problem is encapsulated in the fact that this form is filled in for one trainer and then must be repeated from scratch for every subsequent professional.

8. Competitive Moat & Strategic Positioning

8.1 Technical Moat

The system's defensibility lies not in technology (which has a low barrier to entry) but in domain expertise — deep understanding of trainer and client needs that technology companies lack. The Garmin case study illustrates this principle: despite Apple's unlimited budget, Garmin maintains a 25-year lead in running and cycling because they truly understand user needs. Similarly, this product requires a trainer embedded in the development process, not just technologists.

8.2 Why Big Tech Won't Build This (Yet)

Large technology companies are focused on hardware (watches, bands) and broad-market data consolidation. The problem of coaching, programming, and multi-professional coordination is not attractive to them because it requires deep domain insight and the market appears small relative to hardware markets. Eventually they will address it, but the window of opportunity exists now to establish domain expertise and data quality standards.

8.3 Long-Term Vision

The product is compared to Facebook (built on relationships) and Google (built on data search) — it addresses a fundamental dimension of human existence (physical self-care) and, if captured well, creates defensible competitive advantages through data quality, domain expertise, and network effects between clients and professionals.

9. Target User Profile

Primary demographic: Adults aged 30–45+ years, with the core need intensifying from age 45 onward. This is driven by physiology — the body begins to deteriorate and requires structured maintenance through resistance training. Below age 30, individuals typically work out for competitive or aesthetic goals rather than health maintenance.

Pilot users: High-net-worth individuals who already engage personal trainers, are data-conscious, and would value data ownership. One existing client was described who already manually tracks his own data using a Garmin watch during lifting sessions and photographs the trainer's handwritten log after each session — solving the problem manually with duplication and poor usability.

Personality trait (cross-age): Data-oriented individuals with personal fitness goals. While the age demographic skews older for health-driven adoption, younger users who are detail-oriented and goal-driven may also adopt.

10. Design Decisions & Scope for Prototype

10.1 What to Build First

A data capturing application that connects the individual client with their fitness trainer. The minimum viable product focuses on: structured data entry for training sessions (strength and cardio variables), client ownership of that data, and the ability to share data with a coach.

10.2 What to Defer

The following were explicitly identified as future layers, not prototype functions: computer vision / AI rep-counting (others with large budgets are solving this), video upload and asynchronous coaching review, DNA-based personalisation (no current scientific basis for translation to programming), health tracking and medical checkups (the relationship is inverse — fitness solves health, not vice versa), wearable device integration, blockchain/Web3 for data security, LLM/AI-driven recommendations, and nutrition tracking.

10.3 Data Capture Approach

The first pass uses manual entry only. Computer vision and device integration are deferred but architecturally anticipated. The rationale: anything that works with computer vision will also work with manual entry, so the data model and ownership layer should be built first.

10.4 Privacy and Access Control

Role-based access control is required from the outset in architectural thinking, even if not fully implemented in the prototype. Different professionals need different views: the doctor sees medical constraints, the running coach sees cardio data, the strength coach sees lifting data, family members may see general wellness indicators.

11. Persona for Testing

John Bower will serve as the primary test persona (self-role-playing as a client). This provides authentic domain expertise and ensures the product meets the needs of someone who will actually use it — with the explicit acknowledgment that "if I get pissed off, I'm not going to use it." The prototype must be satisfying enough for a knowledgeable trainer to use for tracking their own data.

12. Additional Context Discussed

Theory of Constraints applied to training: The philosophy that training should identify and optimise the individual's critical path (their limiting factor). When you optimise the constraint, you optimise the system. This applies to individuals with specific limitations (e.g., Ahamed's intermittent breathing condition requiring an inhaler), where standard programs cannot be followed and all programming must account for individual physical constraints.

Fitness solves health (not the reverse): Age-related conditions (pre-diabetes, osteoporosis, cardiovascular disease, menopause symptoms) are emergent phenomena of physical degeneration. Properly structured resistance and cardiovascular training mitigates degeneration. Grip strength and thigh diameter are cited as single-measure predictors of lifespan — proxies for overall muscular and cardiovascular health. The tide of adoption favours this product: as populations age and health problems increase, the demand for structured fitness solutions grows.

13. Action Items & Next Steps

#	Action	Owner	Status
1	Share client intake form (PARQ) via WhatsApp — electronic version	John	Pending
2	Share sample workout log data (Anthony's session) for data model reference	John	Pending
3	Research and validate market claims — scrutinise John's assertions about gaps	Ahamed	Pending
4	Digest meeting content, deep-dive thinking on architecture and starting point	Ahamed	Pending
5	Schedule follow-up session for next week	Both	Pending
6	Explore movement library and muscle activation mapping (open-source availability)	Ahamed	Pending

14. Key Quotes for Reference

- *"The central pain point of this is who owns the data. If you want to understand this and summarise it in a single sentence, it's who owns the data."* — John Bower
- *"All entrepreneurialism is ultimately around organising a disorganised market."* — John Bower
- *"The pain point is rooted in human physiology. So there is no amount of AI which is ever going to take away the pain points."* — John Bower
- *"Garbage in, garbage out. The opportunity here is to start to create a system which collects high-quality data about a person's current health and fitness status."* — John Bower
- *"If we crack this nutshell, that's huge money behind this... It's like Facebook was built on relationships, Google was built on data search. It's a fundamental dimension of human existence."* — Ahamed

15. Recording Notes

This document was synthesised from audio transcriptions captured on two devices (Lenovo laptop and iPhone) during the same session. Minor transcription discrepancies between devices were reconciled by cross-referencing both sources. The recording was stopped before the final portion of the conversation regarding the sample workout data (Anthony's session with movements: French press, bench press, T-bar row).

Document prepared for internal product development reference. Not for external distribution.